used to work. It's easily the hardest I have ever worked with a batting partner. Gary practised like he played – with a lot of heart and determination. He always wanted to get things right. He always believed that you needed to practise specifics, like being able to play the short ball as an opening batter, or else you would quickly be found wanting at international level.

I reckon we could do with commitment like this in the South African team at the moment. It's flipping silly, because we're a little spoilt these days. At practice, either a Corrie van Zyl or a Vinnie Barnes throws at us. The guys won't throw to each other. I know that Gary spends hour upon hour practising in the same way he and I used to with the Indian national team he's currently coaching, so you don't have to wonder why they're currently number one in the world. And why the Proteas aren't …

So ja, I think our attitude and hard work contributed a great deal to our success. Gary and I also knew each other's strengths – if one of us was doing something wrong, we would correct the other. This could be one of the reasons why I couldn't play the same standard of cricket in 2006 and 2007, the last two years I played Test cricket. Graeme Smith simply doesn't do throwdowns.

To be fair to Graeme, though, he can't throw, as his arm is crocked. But ja, the other guys don't throw to each other, not because their arms hurt, but because they actually just don't want to. They'd rather ask Vinnie or current coach Corrie van Zyl to throw to them. Hard-core practising not only made Gary and me a successful opening pair, but it also brought us closer together.

That work ethic is just one side of Gary, though. Most people won't know this, but Gary was a helluva lot of fun off the field. Obviously he made the most of his professional cricket career, but he always had time for a laugh. We used to have this private joke going: every time we'd bump into each other while on tour – like in the lift on the way to breakfast, or at lunch – I'd say to him, 'So, what's news on the Rialto?' It's a line from Shakespeare's *Merchant of Venice*. Don't ask me *why* I remember that particular line – especially given my suspect academic record – but every time I said it, Gary would pack up laughing. 'What's done cannot be undone' is the other snippet of Shakespearean prose I remember. From The Scottish Play, I believe. Weird that I should remember it, isn't it?